



How to Write in Gov20



Common Challenges

- Identifying **what the prompt is asking**
- Writing an easily identifiable **thesis statement**
- Using the whole essay to advance a **single argument**
 - Analyzing, rather than merely summarizing, evidence
 - Tying each paragraph to the main argument
 - Writing concise paragraphs

Deconstructing Essay Prompts

Understanding the Core Question

Before writing, you must decode the prompt's underlying requirements. Prompts in Gov20 always want you to **make an argument about the causes and/or consequences of the big concepts** from the class, such as democratization, economic development, state-building or revolutions. They will often ask you to relate two of those major concepts together to form a cohesive analysis.

Find the key question

HYPOTHETICAL PROMPT NARRATIVE

A prompt discusses a president in a fragile state considering authoritarian measures to build state capacity...

KEY QUESTION

What is your argument for how to build a strong state?

Use the other parts of a prompt (supporting questions, context) to help you build your answer to the key question.

Crafting a Strong Thesis Statement

Criteria for Success

A strong thesis is the backbone of any Gov20 essay. There are three primary criteria for a strong thesis: it must put forth arguable or falsifiable claims; it must be explicit, readily identifiable, and appear early on in the paper; and it must directly respond to the prompt with a **nuanced** argument.

Criterion 1: Puts forth a falsifiable claim

Falsifiable Claim: a claim is falsifiable if you can imagine what empirical evidence would show it to be wrong.

NOT FALSIFIABLE

"In a democracy, a strong civil society is extremely important."

"Many factors contributed to South Korea's industrialization."

FALSIFIABLE CLAIM

"A strong civil society is necessary for a democracy to remain stable." (Empirical statement that can be tested through cases)

Adding Mechanisms to Your Causal Thesis



COMPLETE THESIS EXAMPLE

*"A strong civil society is necessary for a democracy to remain stable, **because civic associations create norms of toleration** that help political opponents work together."*

Criterion 2: Explicit and Readily Identifiable Thesis

Your thesis must be explicit, readily identifiable, and **appear early** on in the paper. It is not enough to have the elements of an argument scattered throughout a paragraph.

COMMON PITFALL TO AVOID

If a reader has to hunt to figure out where your main argument is located among historical observations and summaries of scholarly theories, the thesis is not readily identifiable.

In your introduction, include...

STEP 01

Hook

Mention a specific concept or causal relationship, often serving as a hook.

STEP 02

Argument

State your thesis clearly with few sentences.

STEP 03

Roadmap

Outline the rest of the paper so the reader knows how you will prove your argument step-by-step.

Example intro 1 (not the only way to write an intro)

While scholars like Lipset **would expect an economically growing country like China to democratize**, China seems to have bucked this trend. **I argue that nationalism is key to understanding why China's regime will remain durable, even with economic growth.** When the Chinese regime uses nationalism to make itself appear legitimate, the middle class – a key actor in Lipset's theory – no longer makes demands for democracy. Only when the Chinese regime fails to use nationalism to legitimate itself should we expect the middle class to make democratic demands. **In the following section,** I explain the importance of the middle class in existing theories of democratization. **Then** I show how the middle class behaves differently in China when the regime uses nationalism. **Finally,** I use another Communist country, Poland, to show how Lipset's theory still works when the regime fails to use nationalist rhetoric.

Example intro 2 (not the only way to write an intro)

Comparativists disagree about what drives industrialization, and much of the dispute is over whether late developers must follow the path of early ones. In this essay, **I show that** a combination of Chalmers Johnson's state-led model of development and Alexander Gerschenkron's backwardness theory best explains how Country X surpassed Country Y in GDP per/capita. Gerschenkron shows that backwardness creates an opening for rapid catch-up only if some institution substitutes for missing capital and entrepreneurs, and Johnson shows what that institution was in Country X: an insulated bureaucracy that steered credit and disciplined firms. Country Y was just as backward but never built such a state, so its opening went unused. **In the following section**, I lay out Gerschenkron's argument and show that both countries met his condition of relative backwardness. **Then** I use Johnson to show how Country X's bureaucracy filled the institutional gap, tracing how industrial policy moved resources into manufacturing. **Next**, I turn to Country Y to show that without an insulated developmental bureaucracy, backwardness alone produced stagnation rather than a growth spurt. **Finally**, I address the modernization theorists' objection that Country X's growth would have happened anyway through market forces, and explain why the timing and sector composition of its takeoff point instead to state direction.

Criterion 3: Responding Directly and Non-Trivially to the Prompt

Direct Prompt Engagement

The thesis directly responds to all or a significant portion of the prompt rather than selectively addressing peripheral themes.

Sophisticated & Non-Self-Evident Argument

It must advance a claim that is nuanced, avoiding claims that are obvious or self-evident.

Moving Beyond Summary

Analysis moves past simply summarizing course readings or restating the prompt underlying premise.

Analytical Claim on Variables

Offers a nuanced, analytical claim explicitly articulating the relationship between the core variables in question, as well as mechanisms.

More Tips for a Nice Argument

Know what **type** of argument you are building. Is it voluntarist, institutionalist, structuralist, or a mix?

Empirical and normative claims are different: "Protestantism **causes** capitalism and then development" and "developing countries **should** adopt Protestantism as their religion". Don't let the paper become too normative (a little bit is ok)

Choose one credible explanatory variable – maybe two to interact, not much more than that. Arguments that say "this matters, and also this, and that, and actually everything..." are kitchen sinks, not explanations.

Being **provocative** can be cool! Just make sure you defend your argument based on the course materials.

Unpack causal chain of steps to figure out essay structure

Structure your essay by argument, not through a summary of the readings.

You should be able to create a paragraph-level outline before starting writing which fleshes out what your causal chain is for your argument.

Casual chain...

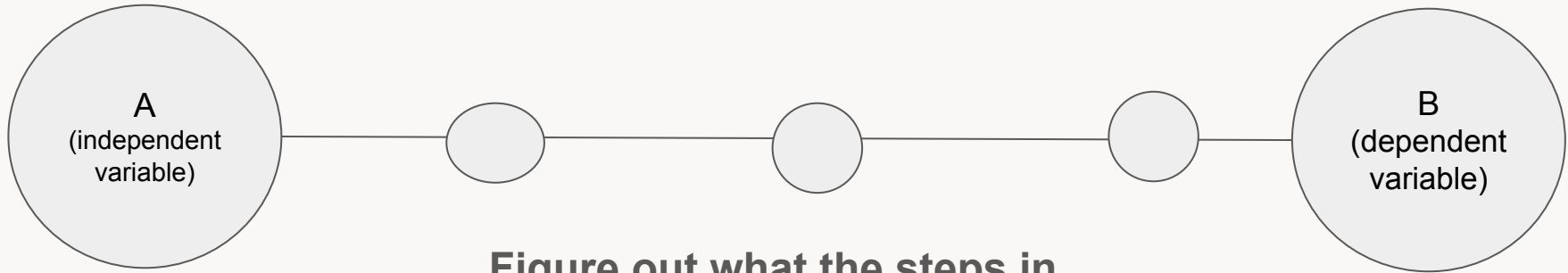


Figure out what the steps in between your independent and dependent variable are.



Let's go back to the earlier example... (simple)

What are the causal steps?



Even to advance each of these claims, there are a series of subclaims you will want to make to get from claim 1 to 2, and so forth.

Paragraph outline (simple example)

Introduction

Section 1 – A strong civil society generates norms of toleration.

Paragraph 1.1... topic sentence

Paragraph 1.2...topic sentence

Paragraph 1.3...topic sentence

Section 2 – Norms of toleration encourage political opponents to cooperate.

Paragraph 2.1... topic sentence

Paragraph 2.2...topic sentence

Paragraph 2.3...topic sentence

Section 3 – Political cooperation keeps democracy stable.

Paragraph 3.1... topic sentence

Paragraph 3.2...topic sentence

Paragraph 3.3...topic sentence

Conclusion

Notice that a summary of the course readings is not being used to structure the essay. Rather, evidence from the readings is strategically being used to advance an argument.

Within each paragraph, focus on fleshing out your topic sentence using analysis (not summary!)

RECOUNTING EVIDENCE

Summary Approach



Recounting historical developments or factual sequences without evaluating theoretical significance.

Example: Chronologically describing South Korea's mid-20th century economic growth policies and institutional updates.

MAKING AN ARGUMENT

Analysis Approach



Interpreting evidence to demonstrate causal chain.

Example: Demonstrating that South Korea's policy transition from **Import-Substituting Industrialization (ISI)** to **Export-Oriented Industrialization (EOI)** forms a necessary condition for late developing countries to industrialize effectively.

Key Insight: Analytical writing can utilize the exact same historical content as a summary paragraph, but re-frames facts to support a broader theoretical claim.

Think about why you are bringing up a reading...

You should use evidence from the reading to make a specific point for **YOUR** argument.

- Are you focusing on a mechanism they bring up?
 - Are you contesting a claim they make?
 - Are you extending a finding of theirs to another situation?
- Etc.

Example paragraph (your paragraph does not have to look exactly like this...)

We can find an example of such a successful industrialization through shifting the economic structure from C policy to D policy in X country. While the state was born out of this military conflict, the Y leader soon strengthened the country's autonomy through A and launched a B to establish the foundation for a well-working internal economy. His authoritarian governmental planning through various five-year as well as six-year plans (Johnson 142) then pushed X's economy to becoming almost fully self-sufficient and thus followed the structure of an C policy. However, Y leader simultaneously understood the very limited opportunity for his country to industrialize given the international circumstances while only relying on C as an economic structure. He consequently soon realized the necessity of his country to selectively open up to foreign investments which turned out to be the crucial step for X in eventually becoming the modernized, industrialized country as we know it today (Soroka, lecture 6). Therefore, the example of X helps us understand that a shift from C to D forms a necessary condition for late developing countries to industrialize effectively.

Tips for figuring out what your causal chain is...

No AI Use.

1. You've got all of college in front of you. Any job you want to have > intense information processing + decision making. Commit to developing your skills on this front.
 2. We have in-person exams. Use every assignment as a tool to learn and review concepts.
 3. The goal is not to be perfect – it is to learn over time and get better.
 4. We can tell when AI is being used.
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Tip 1 – Where to look for evidence...

- Draw from a mix of lectures and readings (especially readings, because you need to demonstrate that you've grappled with them).
- Stick to course materials. While drawing on outside materials is allowed, it might work against you if it takes you away from focusing on the readings.

Tip 2 - Find important cases to demonstrate your argument.

CASE TYPE 01

Single Case

Use a single case to illustrate a mechanism at work.

CASE TYPE 02

Negative Case

Use a negative case to show what happens when a mechanism isn't working.

CASE TYPE 03

Counter-Conventional

Use a case to show why the conventional wisdom is insufficient, which motivates the need for your new argument.

CORE REQUIREMENT

Overall, it is most important that you demonstrate the implications of your argument for what we should observe in the world.

See the Samuels reading for a discussion on the comparative method.
You can mix and match these kinds of different cases to advance distinct pieces of your argument.

Tip 3 - Ask what the counterfactual is.

Starting claim

Claim 1: A strong civil society generates norms of toleration.

Claim 2: Norms of toleration encourage cooperation.

Counterfactual claim

Counterfactual 1: When civil society is weak, politics is characterized by intolerance and distrust.

Counterfactual 2: Without these norms, politicians engage in destructive behavior.

Tip 4 – As you are constructing your argument, make your scope conditions very clear.

- Under what conditions do we expect to hold true? Outside of these conditions, reflect on whether your argument could still apply.

Tip 5 – If you choose to engage with a counterargument, do so in a nuanced way.

WEAK APPROACH

Briefly mentioning an opposing view and dismissing it without analysis.

Example: "Some critics argue that economic growth alone drives stability, but this is incorrect."

STRONG APPROACH

Directly engaging with the counter-argument, deconstructing its logic, and showing why your causal mechanism are correct.

Example: "Critics argue that rapid economic growth alone can stabilize democracies. However, this overlooks how growth without civic associations often triggers elite capture, making democratization even more fragile."

Key Insight: Directly refuting opposing logic proves the robustness of your causal steps and preempts potential counter-claims.

Last bits + tips for editing

Basic definitions

Define variables + concepts (e.g. "state capacity", "development") in less than 3 sentences

If you need more than 3 sentences, there probably is a more specific term for the concept you are targeting



Paragraph checklist

1. Give every paragraph *a* defined function

Why is this paragraph important or useful to my argument?

2. Don't do everything in the same paragraph

Avoid crowding multiple unrelated ideas into one paragraph. Break distinct ideas into new paragraphs.

3. Be concise

As a rule of thumb, don't let a paragraph go on for more than a page.

Signpost effectively

The topic sentence of each paragraph should tell the reader what you will be arguing in the paragraph.

- *"First, it is important to address Lipset's theory."*
- *"Existing theories of democratization that fail to explain China assume that a growing middle class will demand democracy."*

Strong sign posting approach

Does this topic sentence tell the reader what I argue in this paragraph?

Write a “Reverse Outline”

To refine your structure and improve logic flow, write a reverse outline.

STEP 1



Read First Paragraph

Read your first paragraph.

STEP 2



State Goal & Function

Write down its function and goal in one sentence. Bonus points if this is your topic sentence!

STEP 3



Repeat

Repeat for each paragraph in the essay body.

How to end the essay? Concluding paragraph

Recap argument:

→ What's the main point? What evidence have you used

Talk about why it matters

→ What's the so what?

Contextualize your argument

→ Under what conditions would your argument *not* apply?

Citations

Use a consistent citation style & cite page numbers.

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2. Stick to course materials. While drawing on outside materials is allowed, it might work against you if it takes you away from focusing on the readings.

Style Notes: Voice, Tone, and Scholarly Precision

Core guidelines for effective academic writing

- Write how you speak, avoiding flowery language.
- Use active voice and "I" statements.
- Avoid general terms like "factors."
- Crucially, avoid hard language unless you can back it up; instead of "proving" something, you have probably "demonstrated" it. Instead of saying economic growth "causes" democracy, note that it "encourages" it.
- Finally, read your paper once through aloud to detect and improve awkward syntax and grammatical errors.

Final Gov20 Writing Checklist

✓ **1. Argument-first process, then iterate**

Start with argument, write an outline, see if they agree, and rinse and repeat

✓ **2. Use evidence from course to support your argument, not the other way around**

Ensure your essay structure is built around your argument, not the course readings.

✓ **3. Edit your argument's flow**

Confirm that each paragraph serves a single function and is introduced with a signposting topic sentence.

✓ **4. Conclude and nuance your argument (*optional*)**

Write your conclusion, and if you would like add a counter argument

Questions?